

states RAJASTHAN

Raje manages to avert the Gurjar crisis with some adroit political and diplomatic negotiations, but the demand for reservations could spread to other castes in Rajasthan

■ By Rohit Parihar

In the end, it came as something of an anticlimax. After weeks of violent agitation, deaths in police firing and blockades of key rail and road links in Rajasthan, Chief Minister Vasundhara Raje and her formidable foe, Gurjar leader Colonel Kirori Singh Bainsla, bowed to each other as they called a truce. The Colonel even saluted her in true military style, in acknowledgement of her political and diplomatic skills in pulling the state back from the brink of a serious crisis and forging an agreement that has far-reaching political implications, in the state and outside. "These were certainly amongst most challenging times of my political career," Raje told INDIA TODAY, immediately after the agreement was signed late on June 18 evening. She looked grim and weary but relieved that the ordeal was over and her status and image as a leader remained intact, perhaps even enhanced. The agreement with the Gurjar leadership was a political masterstroke which has put the onus back on the Congress-led UPA and boosted her own political fortunes.

The agreement gives special status to Gurjars, but more importantly grants 14 per cent reservation to the economically-backward, which includes other castes and the rural poor who were left out in the caste-based reservation. With this, she has not only saved herself from being accused of pleasing the Gurjars, but will be now setting the agenda for national politics. "The nation will now debate how to help the deserving poor irrespective of caste," she says. Her initiative is bound to boost the poll prospects of BJP in the Lok Sabha elections, pushing the Congress into a tight corner. Her strategy was well thought-out. She had tried to put the ball in the Centre's court when the Gurjars demanded Scheduled Tribe (ST) status but when that failed, she switched her focus with the idea of bringing the leaders to the



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negotiation table and convincing them to accept special reservation instead. On June 18, when Colonel Bainsla met her in the chief minister's secretariat for the first time since he launched the second phase of the agitation, he saluted her as a general would do a worthy opponent, before proceeding to the dais where 30 other Gurjar representatives were seated. There, Bainsla, announced, "Now we will ask the Central Government to give us Scheduled Tribe status."

That is where Raje has scored. By granting them an exclusive 5 per cent reservation as a special category, apart from compensation and benefits to victims of the police firing, she has ensured that it does not eat into any other caste-based reservation share. Although the exact implementation is still to be worked out, she has neu-

tralised any chances of upper caste anger at losing general category share by announcing the 14 per cent reservation for economically-backward castes who do not get any caste-based reservation. Her biggest achievement has been to convince Bainsla that the Gurjars cannot get Scheduled Tribe status under the current criteria and their only hope is to approach the Centre. For Bainsla, it was a bait that he could not resist. He can claim to have obtained exclusive reservation status for Gurjars whose biggest grievance was that they were marginalised by dominating Jats, Yadavs and most other castes in the OBC category, losing the opportunity for government jobs as well as in panchayats, local bodies and assembly and parliament elections to the Meenas.

The new formula granted by Raje